culture. The basic concept of Hindu *rashtra* is that the culture is nurtured here. Those who think that this culture is right—they are *Bharatiya*. When anyone feels that his or her culture is Arabic or Roman, then differences crop up. The predecessors of 98 per cent of Christians and Muslims are actually Hindu by race.'[40]

This is why, at the seventy-fifth Vijayadashami speech of the RSS, Bhagwat's predecessor K.S. Sudarshan made an impassioned plea to Muslims, saying that they have the 'blood of Rama and Krishna in their veins'. He said, 'Indian Muslims should realise that their ancestors did not come from a foreign land. So why don't they work for the Indianisation of Islam and give a new shape to their religion?'[41] This theme of indigenising Islam and Christianity is a familiar trope in RSS messaging. Sudarshan's 2000 speech was typical: calling for both a 'swadeshikaran' (indigenisation) of Christianity (through the setting up of a nationalised church) and an 'Indianisation' of Islam (asking Muslims to adopt Ram and Krishna as national icons that were part of their ancestral heritage).[42]

In the same vein, in 2020, the RSS listed a question on the FAQs page of its website on whether a Muslim or a Christian can join up as a member. Its answer deserves to be quoted in full:[43]

Christians and Muslims who live in Bharat have not come from an alien land, rather they are all children of this nation. All our forefathers and ancestors are from this country. If for any reason, a person changes his religion then that does not mean that they should change their values and vision towards life. So Christians, Muslims or people following any other religion who live in Bharat & who subscribe to the world view of Bharat are all 'Hindus'. They are welcome to be in the RSS. In fact, several such 'Hindus' do come into RSS, take active part in Sangh's activities towards nation building and work with full responsibility. They are neither discriminated against nor do they receive any special treatment.

The RSS often says that it draws its intellectual lineage from late-nineteenth and turn-of-the-century spiritual figures like Swami Vivekanand, Swami Dayanand, Lokmanya Tilak and Sri Aurobindo